AIHOLE: CRADLE OF INDIAN TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE (?????)

ARCHAEOLOGICAL AND ARCHITECTURAL HERITAGE

Aihole, anciently called Aryapura, is a historic temple village on the Malaprabha River in Bagalkot district. Known as the laboratory and cradle of Hindu and Jain rock-cut and structural temple architecture, Aihole contains over 120 stone temples dating between the 5th and 12th centuries CE built by Chalukya master craftsmen.

THE FAMOUS DURGA TEMPLE

The Durga Temple (built late 7th to early 8th century CE) is Aihole's architectural centerpiece. Named after the surrounding Durg (protective fort rampart), it is celebrated for its unique apsidal (horseshoe-shaped or gajaprishta) plan resembling early Buddhist chaitya halls. It features a peripteral colonnaded corridor with masterfully sculpted bracket panels of Mahishasuramardini, Varaha, and Shiva with Nandi.

LAD KHAN, RAVANA PHADI, AND MEGUTI INSCRIPTION

Lad Khan Temple:

A 5th-6th century CE temple originally serving as a royal assembly hall before being converted into a Shiva shrine. Features a square cave-like pillared hall, sloped stone roof slabs with timber-imitation joinery, and exquisite floral lattice stone windows.

Ravana Phadi Cave:

A 6th-century rock-cut Shaivite cave sanctuary featuring a majestic ten-armed dancing Shiva Nataraja accompanied by Ganesha, Kartikeya, and the Saptamatrikas (Seven Mother Goddesses).

Meguti Hill Jain Temple & The Aihole Inscription (634 CE):

Constructed atop Meguti Hill in 634 CE by the royal court poet Ravikirti during the reign of Chalukya Emperor Pulakeshin II. The temple wall bears the famous Aihole Sanskrit Inscription written in early Old Kannada-Telugu script, describing Pulakeshin II's military conquests and his historic victory over Emperor Harsha of Kannauj on the banks of the Narmada River.